

Open source in 2012

THE YEAR ahead in the free world

<Open source platforms such as apache, chromium and sqlite have continued to grow despite closed source alternatives> **By Kshitij Sobti**

The open source movement continues to strengthen every year, such that no matter who you are, what software you use, what book you read, whatever you do somewhere along the line open source software is in use.

2011 has been a good year for open source, and now we look forward to what we think are some important developments to look out for in 2012 in the field of open source. We've classified open source software mentioned in this article under the headings of "Web", "Mobile" and "Desktop".

WEB

HTML5 / CSS3 / JavaScript / other standards

A number of standards are emerging that make 2012 an interesting year for web standards. The Mouse Lock and GamePad APIs aim to improve the state of web games.

CSS3 has added a number of new specifications; Exclusions and Regions allow print style layouts; Flexible Box makes it easier to develop user interfaces; and CSS3 Paged media allows pagination for better access than scrolling on devices; and more.

Mozilla's WebAPI specifications are also being developed and matured, and cover everything needed to develop applications for mobile, from access to battery status, to contacts and SMS.

Mozilla Boot2Gecko

Boot to Gecko is Mozilla's attempt to make a mobile operating system that is completely open, and applications are written using web standard languages such as HTML, CSS and JavaScript. 2012 should see the release of preview versions of this OS.

WordPress

WordPress' meteoric rise is far from over. WordPress 3.3 just managed to release near the end of the year, and WordPress 3.4, 3.5 and 3.6 are likely to release in 2012. WordPress has tried to make it easier for developers to use the CMS with each release, and we can expect great things from it this coming year.

Mozilla Firefox

Firefox has a good year ahead of it; 2012 will see the release of Firefox 10 to 18, and some great things like in these releases. In Firefox 10 and 11 Mozilla will expand on the collection of developer tools available in Firefox to include a style editor, an inspector, a debugger and more.

Lying further ahead is an overhaul of Firefox's interface, a new tab page, a home tab, the ability to push a tab from desktop to mobile, a new download manager, support for installing web apps, and much more. Also releasing is a version of Firefox for tablets, and Firefox for Android with a native UI.

Google Chrome

Google Chrome has now surpassed Mozilla Firefox in usage and it is likely that it will keep growing. For good or bad Google is continuing to push the envelope of web applications. Native Client, which allows you to write code for web apps in native languages such as C++ is maturing and can greatly improve web app performance. Google's Dart might also make it into the browser in some form in 2012.

MOBILE

PhoneGap / Apache Callback

PhoneGap aims to make it possible to develop web applications that run natively on mobile. With an extended API, PhoneGap apps can access device features such as compass, contacts, notifications and vibration. The app can then be packed for any and all of iOS, Android, BlackBerry OS, webOS, Symbian, bada, and Windows Phone. Adobe bought Nitobi, its creators, and contributed this project to Apache. Adobe added support for creating and testing PhoneGap applications in Dreamweaver CS5.5 and it is likely more integration will come in the future.

jQuery Mobile

If you're a web developer, it's a given you've heard of jQuery. jQuery Mobile is a jQuery-based framework for developing websites that work well on mobile. The framework makes it easy to create good looking, touch-friendly websites for mobiles without even needing to touch JavaScript or CSS. It can automatically enhance your HTML site if you give it a few hints. jQuery Mobile had its first major 1.0 release just recently and 2012 should see more releases now that the basic stuff is done. Combined with Apache Callback above, it is a great tool for making simple web applications.

webOS

HP has just announced that it will open source webOS. Despite the recent turbulent times for this OS, by becoming open source it should live on in some form or the other no matter what. HP will also be opening its ENYO framework for making applications for webOS. With any new open source project comes a barrage of new development and improvements, and ports to different platforms. webOS should be no different. Both Tizen and Boot to Gecko are similar products and might gain from this. 2012 should be exciting year indeed for this under-appreciated OS.

Plasma Active

Plasma Active is a project by KDE for creating a tablet-centric UI based on the KDE Framework that is completely open source, yet powerful to use. In the short time since its announcement, Plasma